



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Wilmington Preschool of the Arts and Classical Day School
School Website: <https://www.wilmingtonartspreschoolinc.com/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Wilmington Preschool of the Arts (WPA) in Wilmington, NC 28403 demonstrates strengths in parent-partnership and community connection, but its public materials do not align with a fully classical six-element rubric. Across the six categories, WPA shows clear alignment with modern, child-centered, play-based early education in terms of pedagogy, curriculum breadth for early childhood, and familial engagement. However, the site does not present explicit evidence of classical elements such as Great Books, rigorous Socratic dialogue, traditional liberal-arts tria, or explicitly catechetical or liturgical practices. On balance, WPA sits primarily in the Not Classical to Somewhat Classical range, with the strongest alignment in Parents & Community and a more tentative alignment in Faculty.

Executive takeaway by category (high-level):

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: NOT CLASSICAL
- Purpose and Goal: NOT CLASSICAL
- Curriculum: NOT CLASSICAL
- Pedagogy: NOT CLASSICAL
- Faculty: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Parents & Community: CLASSICAL

Aggregate assessment: NOT CLASSICAL

Key evidence anchors:

- Prominent emphasis on virtue-like concepts such as care, safety, curiosity, love of learning, and holistic development, but without explicit transcendental or theological framing, liturgical practice, or Great Books commitments. The site foregrounds Golden Rule ethics, partnership with families, and a warm, child-centered approach (evidence: "Golden Rule," family partnership, and development-focused aims).
- Strong parental involvement and open communication with families (evidence: "Partnering with Families... daily digital communication, parent-teacher conferences" and open access to visits).
- Curriculum and program descriptions emphasize play, social-emotional development, and early literacy/numeracy with enrichment options, but no explicit Great Books or classical core-curriculum signals (evidence: preschool, pre-K, and enrichment program descriptions).

Note: The Classical Elements lexicon (Six Essential Elements) and accompanying keyword lists provide the framework against which WPA is measured. The school's public materials align with modern, progressive early-childhood language rather than the classical lexicon's explicitly enumerated terms (e.g., Great Books, Socratic seminars, liturgical practices, classical memory work). See the classicality lexicon for reference terms used in scoring across six elements (Positive Keywords and Negative Signals).

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- WPA public materials emphasize a Golden Rule orientation and a safety-centered, welcoming environment rather than explicit transcendent moral realism or liturgical life. The central narrative is about curiosity, safe learning, and parental partnership, not theological or liturgical formation. For example, the “A Compass for Future Learning” frames the approach around the Golden Rule and a curriculum that supports students and parents rather than a theological frame.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive: None clearly reflective of transcendental moral realism, theology, or liturgical life in WPA materials.
- Negative: The absence of explicit theological or liturgical framing is a negative signal in the classical lexicon’s terms for this category.

Why this rating

- The absence of explicit religious/metaphysical foundations and liturgical practice signaling in WPA’s public-facing content places it outside classical expectations for this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- WPA emphasizes preparation for future growth, character through a values-forward lens (Golden Rule), and fostering curiosity, rather than a classic telos focused on virtue formation in the transcendent sense. The “Our Approach” section emphasizes partner-family goals, skills development (communication, motor, problem-solving), and a curriculum designed to support ongoing growth rather than forming virtue toward a classical telos.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: “curiosity,” “love of learning,” “character development” (implicit in development language) — but not in the classical sense of a telos toward truth, goodness, and beauty as real, knowable ends.
- Negative keywords present: none explicit; however, the explicit classical ends (truth/goodness/beauty as ends) are not foregrounded.

Why this rating

- The public-facing purpose aligns with modern formation and growth rather than the classical triad (truth, goodness, beauty) as end toward which human life is oriented.

Element 3: School Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- WPA describes age-appropriate, play-based curricula across Toddlers, Preschool, and Pre-K with enrichment programs, rather than a Great Books-centric liberal arts or classical curriculum. Content focuses on foundational literacy/numeracy, social-emotional skills, and enrichment. There is no explicit mention of Great Books, Great Conversation, Latin/Greek, or the liberal arts tria in the site copy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: “play-based learning,” “learning through play,” “art, music, movement, language” (reflective of a broad early-childhood curriculum rather than classical canon).
- Negative keywords present: absence of Great Books, grammar/logic/rhetoric progression, or historical canon beyond broad “history” concepts—none explicitly stated.

Why this rating

- The curriculum is robust for early childhood development but does not reflect classical curriculum markers (grammar/logical/rhetorical trinity; Great Books; comprehensive history as a core through the curriculum). Therefore NOT CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- WPA emphasizes a warm, relational, contemplative, play-based approach with singing and circle-time in early years, memory and engagement rather than a strictly Socratic/seminar-based approach in practice. The site describes “Joyful and Meaningful Play-based Learning,” with a strong emphasis on relationships, routines, and exploration. There is explicit note of singing in Toddlers and a strong emphasis on memory through song in lower levels, which aligns with a traditional pedagogy but not with the classical pedagogy’s typical emphasis on Socratic discussions and rhetorical training in the upper grades.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: “singing,” “circle time,” “memory,” “group projects,” “cooperation,” and “memory work” (these terms appear in WPA’s pedagogy and program descriptions and align with a more traditional, musical/memory-based pedagogy, but not the strict classical pedagogy emphasis on Socratic seminars or rational discourse).
- Negative keywords present: absence of explicit Socratic seminars, dialectic discourse, or formal rhetoric training in K-8 within WPA materials.

Why this rating

- While there are elements of contemplative, memory-based pedagogy (e.g., singing, circle-time memory), the absence of explicit Socratic/Paideia-style seminars and formal rhetoric instruction in the lower grades signals a NOT CLASSICAL pedagogy.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- WPA emphasizes a dedicated staff, with a Center Director who has decades of experience, and a shared approach where teachers act as facilitators and observers, with a living curriculum feel. The materials describe teachers as partners and facilitators rather than distant technicians, and the director has a visible role in guiding the school’s culture. This aligns with a semblance of the classical “living curriculum” and teacher as mentor, though not explicitly framed as “masters” or “portrait of the teacher.”

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: “teacher,” “facilitators,” “partners,” “relationship-based learning,” “living curriculum” (concepts that map toward a classical-fluid teacherly mentorship, even if not named with the formal classical terms).
- Negative keywords present: none explicit in WPA materials denoting anti-classical teaching; the absence of a formal “portrait of the teacher” language in WPA materials may be a gap relative to classical norms.

Why this rating

- WPA shows strong teacher engagement, mentorship vibe, and a collaborative culture, which is in line with some classical elements (teacher as mentor, living curriculum). However, it lacks explicit classical staff-lifecycle signals (portrait of a teacher, master-teacher model with formal classical training). Thus, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully Classical.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- WPA foregrounds strong parent partnership, families as co-educators, open lines of communication, and frequent parent involvement (Request Info, tours, parent conferences, daily digital updates). The site specifically emphasizes “Partnering with Families, Building Brighter Futures,” and describes home–center collaboration and frequent parental involvement in the learning process.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: “Partnership with Families,” “parents as co-teachers,” “home and school connection,” “parent-teacher conferences,” “daily digital communications,” “family involvement,” “engaged families,” “community of learners.”
- Negative keywords present: The classical lexicon lists negative signals such as “consumer language” or minimal parent involvement; WPA’s materials strongly oppose those, signaling alignment with classical ideals here.

Why this rating

- The strongest classical-alignment signal is a robust, explicit partnership with families, parental engagement, and community integration—core Classical elements in the Parents & Community category per the Six Essential Elements lexicon.

Aggregate assessment: NOT CLASSICAL

Rationale

- Four of six categories are NOT CLASSICAL; one category is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL (Faculty), and one category is CLASSICAL (Parents & Community). The majority alignment skews Not Classical. The overall posture of WPA reflects modern, student-centered early education with strong family engagement, but it does not present the canonical classical core—great books, Socratic pedagogy, liturgical life, or a fully articulated classical curriculum across grades. The aggregate places the school in NOT CLASSICAL territory.

What would move the needle (only applicable if some categories were SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL)

- Not applicable for broad needle-moving changes given the aggregate NOT CLASSICAL rating. If you want to push toward CLASSICAL, targeted changes could include:
- Explicit incorporation of classical curriculum elements: Great Books and a more explicit Trivium structure (grammar, logic, rhetoric) across elementary levels and a historically grounded humanities sequence.
- Introduce Socratic seminars and disciplined rhetoric work in upper elementary/middle grades; schedule formal Latin or classical language study, and align assessment with traditional memory work and recitation.
- Add liturgical or liturgy-adjacent communal practices to create liturgical rhythm and reverence within a non-sectarian classical frame.
- Develop a formal “portrait of the teacher” and professional development path anchored in classical pedagogy, including ongoing teacher seminars on classical methodologies and living-books pedagogy.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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